

*Tomato*

‘I mean so little,’ I whisper into an empty cup.

“Sarah,” my cousin pokes.

She leads in with her rosey hips. Straight into the house, her belly casts a shadow. My family of sisters are all in my kitchen. Two pots are boiling. Shouting spreads from the living room.

“It’s nearly ready,” my cousin laughs, holding her stomach as she sits at the table.

“Here, feel,” she grabs my hand.

My clumsy white polish is chipped. Dirt darkens my fingernails, and cuts line my fingers. Still, she places it.

“See,” she says.

I feel two pulses. Someone else's dreams bubble with ferment. I don’t dare open my mouth. So, I swallow it whole.

“And they wear it so effortlessly,” chatters from the table break my spell.

The platter is empty. Save for scattered seeds, pepper edges, and a few carrots with blush. I snatch up the plate.

“Let me get some more,” I say while walking into the kitchen. Above the sink, a window peers across a fresh-cut lawn. I walk out barefoot and let my feet sink in.

I laugh. My grandfather used to grow these when I was young. I think of him and now. The me here tending his garden. Did he know he was the last one? Did he think that when my Father was killed? Do they *all* think that’s why?

I spray my feet with the hose and walk back in. I miss the sound of collars. White, blue, and pink, all wagging their way into the future. Now, it’s mostly silent.

I wash the earth off my grandfather’s plants. As I scrub, it makes sense. I bring shadows and toiling years in the dirt. She brings milk to her honey.

I place the extras in a bag. She moves from her new center. It’s slightly lower, causing her feet to splay.

“Here, you’re eating for two,” I thrust the bag her way.

“Aww, thanks hon.” She says, and waddles back.

Thunder cracks, the storm outside has gathered, and it pours. I head back to the sink. I open the window and smell magnolias. I start chopping vegetables. My cousin’s husband walks up.

“Thanks,” the husband blurts out, reaching for a cigarette as I shake my head no.

“Right.” he nods, tucking it back in.

The rain patters down in full torrential force. I hear it smack each leaf, then swell into the ground.

“Look,” he grabs my shoulder, “Your Dad would be proud. You’ve taken care of all these women, right!”

I stare.

“I mean you too.”

He slaps my back and grabs from the replenished platter. I inhale, and before I exhale, it comes from the kitchen table,

“And she wears it so well.”

I stay at the window and stare. The garden drinks the rain. I hope it doesn’t take the tomatoes, but surely it must. There’s laughing from the table.

“I mean so little to everyone here,” I whisper to a full cup, “and that’s exactly how it should be.”